

SIX FACES OF DEATH

A dark fantasy adventure for characters of 11th to 13th level



An alien being, dark omens, and vanishing ships send the adventurers to a mysterious island newly appeared in the Sea of Swords. But can the characters uncover the mysteries of the Changing Island in time to save Faerûn from a terror from another plane?

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Beyond the Material Plane lie dimensions where gods and devils dwell, and where pure ideals are embodied in physical form. One such place is Mechanus, the plane of ultimate law, where the geometric modrons maintain absolute order. Another is Acheron, home to endless battlefields of law and evil, where reborn warriors fight eternal conflicts of metal and blood.

No stars or suns appear in the skies of Acheron—only floating metal cubes hurtling through the void. One of these was Cube 1717, designed by a mad derro architect named Avnas, and ruled by a powerful devil named Earl Andromalius—a servant of the god of tyranny, Lord Bane.

Cube 1717's primary purpose was as a battle station in Acheron's endless wars. But it also contained a prison and laboratory where horrifying experiments were carried out upon court-martialed soldiers and other doomed souls. Some became food for horrid monsters. Others were used for weapons testing and destroyed by steel and hellfire. Once, three particularly cunning conspirators who tried to unseat Earl Andromalius were fused together into a horrible undead entity—a skull lord named Vargo, doomed to suffer forever in the prisons of the cube.

UNEXPECTED VISITOR

Not long ago, a planar rift brought an unusual creature to Acheron, where it was discovered by Earl Andromalius's servants. It was a quadrone—one of the cubical warriors of the modrons, left broken in body and mind by being cut off from the order of Mechanus.

When the creature was brought to Avnas, the insane derro subjected it to bizarre experiments that drove the already unstable quadrone completely mad. Under the duress of the testing, the quadrone was corrupted by the magic of Acheron to develop a heretofore unheard-of power: the ability to control other beings and make them into creatures like itself.

Exponentially growing in power and size, the Archquadrone escaped its captivity and penetrated to the engine room at the heart of Cube 1717. There, it fused its body with the cube's engines, creating a living brain whose first task was to instigate the deadly **pixelating curse**—a magical malady that transforms creatures and objects into lawful neutral cube creatures serving the dictates of the Archquadrone.

The infection spread quickly throughout Cube 1717, transforming thousands of Acheronian soldiers into cube-like mockeries of life. Earl Andromalius was killed and overthrown, and with the power of Cube 1717 at their command, the Archquadrone's cube-creatures soon threatened Acheron itself.

To deal with this threat, the princes and dukes of Acheron were forced to seek the aid of the yugoloths—mercenary creatures of pure evil. The strength of their combined forces allowed the devils and the yugoloths to besiege the cube, slaughtering its defenders. In the end, the yugoloths were forced to use the River Styx as a weapon, inundating Cube 1717 with its waters to cleanse both the memories of the dead and the curse that infected them.

PREPARATION AND PLANNING

Six Faces of Death is a dark fantasy adventure featuring countless fiends, mind control, strange physical transformations, and dead bodies by the thousands. Before running the scenario, you'll want to make sure that your players are aware that the adventure features plenty of dark imagery and horror themes. Even then, you might want to downplay some of the more graphic descriptions contained herein, according to your own sensibilities as a DM and the ages and sensitivities of your players.

The adventure is also a dangerous one—and might prove a challenge even for powerful 11th-to-13th-level characters! On the bright side, though, the scenario also features a lot of humor that you can use to lighten the overall dark tone. And as with many *Dungeons & Dragons* adventures, the difficulty level can be adjusted on the fly by giving the characters allies (the monodrone, the shadar-kai, the drow, and potentially even the oinoloth and the hydroloths), making sure they learn appropriate background information before they travel to the mysterious island, and adjusting the efficiency of the enemies' lair defense.

Before the adventure begins, take note of whether any characters are chaotic. This is important in determining how resistant they are to the Archquadrone's pixelating curse.

To run a particularly dangerous version of the adventure, use pregenerated characters and start the adventure with a shipwreck that leaves the party stranded on the Changing Island with no preparation. Can the characters uncover the island's many mysteries—and how long will they survive as they try?

Attempting to escape, the Archquadrone's pixelated servants tore open a planar rift that sent Cube 1717 hurtling into the Material Plane. In a storm of fire and infernal energy, the cube appeared above the Sea of Swords in western Faerûn before sinking into its depths.

SIGNS AND SURVIVORS

Most of the Archquadrone's servants died and were unpixelated in the Styx's purifying waters. But deep within the cube—at the bottom of the Sea of Swords and still surrounded by a bubble of black Styx water—a handful of entities survived: Avnas the derro, whose chaotic nature had temporarily protected her from the pixelation; a group of abishai priests of Tiamat who were protected by the power of a sacred statue of their god; and the skull lord Vargo, who managed to escape its imprisonment during the chaos of the battle. (See *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more on the derro, the abishai, and the skull lord.)

Exploring the sunken cube's lightless depths, Vargo came to the central engine room, where it found the Archquadrone failing and close to destruction. With the combined intelligence of its three heads, Vargo discovered that it could attach those heads to parts of the Archquadrone's six-sided brain to bring Cube 1717 back to life—and to make itself the cube's master. The control system Vargo created is called the Six-Face Throne, a complex device that has allowed the skull lord to restore the cube's internal power and gravity systems, and to bring it to the surface of the Sea of Swords.

Word of the cube's destination reached the yugoloths, who became alarmed at it having been reactivated—and doubly alarmed that the Acheronians might ask for their money back. A strike force sent out to finish the job of destroying the cube ended in failure, though—and with the capture of an oinoloth that was one of the force's leaders. The hextons of Mechanus sent their own forces to finish the job, but those too were overcome. Word of this strange new island then brought numerous sailors and explorers into the area to investigate, but all have been killed or captured—with survivors forced to join Vargo's pixelated army.

THE CALL TO ADVENTURE

When an important NPC vanishes in the area of the mysterious island, the adventurers are inspired or called upon to investigate. Traveling to the Changing Island with a mad monodrone (a survivor of the modron strike force) as their guide, they must find and rescue their pixelated friend, defeat the skull lord, and end the curse.

But Vargo has been waiting for just such an opportunity, hoping to entice highly intelligent adventurers to the island. By grafting the severed heads of those individuals onto its own body, the undead hopes to become a six-headed skull lord and fully reactivate Cube 1717, turning it into a flying, mobile battle station with thousands of pixel soldiers under its undead command.

Can the adventurers stop the combined forces of pure evil and pure law? Or will all Faerûn become a pixelated wasteland in thrall to the six faces of death?

CHARACTERS AND FACTIONS

The following roster summarizes the key NPCs and monsters the characters are likely to meet during the adventure.

CONTROLLERS OF THE CUBE

Vargo and its servants control Cube 1717, and will do whatever it takes to maintain the skull lord's hold on the cube's power.

Vargo. Created from the bodies of three evil adventurers, the **skull lord**[™] Vargo has spent hundreds of years in Acheron. The personalities of the undead's three heads have merged over that time. It commands all the pixelated creatures and controls three faces of the Six-Face Throne—two directly, and the third



SKULL LORD

through its servant, Sladek. Vargo seeks sufficiently intelligent adventurers to graft onto itself, allowing it to activate the cube's full power and conquer Faerûn. See area 6.31 for more information.

Sladek. A genasi mage who journeyed to the island and became pixelated, Sladek is the NPC who inspires the characters' rescue mission—but they are unaware that he is now a pixelated **mage**, one of Vargo's allies, and one of the controllers of the Six-Face Throne. The most intelligent of the pixelated creatures transformed by the cube, Sladek now seeks to spread the pixelating curse to every living creature. See area 6.11B for more information.

Avnas. This crazed **derro savant**[™] is a mad scientist, an architect, and the only survivor of Earl Andromalius's retinue. She serves Vargo out of a mad desire to see what might happen if the skull lord is able to claim the power it seeks. See area 6.17 for more information.

Bunch. A **berbalang** that came to the island to gather the bones of the dead, Bunch is resistant to the pixelating curse because of the creature's extraplanar nature. (The **berbalang** appears in *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*.) It serves Vargo in return for skulls and bones. See area 6.13 for more information.

Balhannoth and Oblex. A **balhannoth** was brought onto the island by a party of drow explorers as a servitor monster. Transformed into a pixelated creature, it now serves Vargo and Sladek. An **adult oblex** is the product of one of the horrid experiments conducted

MONSTERS AND MAGIC

Most of the monsters in this adventure are taken from *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*. When a monster name appears in bold, it means that creature appears either in that book or the *Monster Manual*. The first time a monster appears in the adventure, the text notes if it appears in *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*. If the name appears in bold thereafter, a superscript 'M' indicates that the creature appears in that book.

A number of new magic items found on Cube 1717 are found in the "New Magic Items" appendix at the end of the adventure. All other magic items are found in the *Dungeon Master's Guide*.

in Cube 1717's laboratory. It, too, serves the skull lord. The balhannoth and the oblex both appear in *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*. See "Face 5: Beautiful Island" for more information.

OTHER FACTIONS

A number of creatures within the cube might prove to be friends or foes to the characters—or both.

'Nameless.' Met by the characters at the start of the mission, this mad **monodrone** has suffered damage that has caused it to go rogue. Terrified of the "bad square boss" inside the cube island, it picks one of the characters as its new boss and latches onto them, following them anywhere—but communication with the creature is difficult. See "Mad Monodrone," below, for more information.

Fern. The only survivor of a shadar-kai expedition to explore the island, Fern is a shadar-kai **shadow dancer** with partial memory loss as a result of contact with Styx water. She seeks to find Astilbe, a fallen friend. See area 1.3 for more information on Fern, and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more on the shadar-kai.

Simak. This **drow house captain** is the only survivor of a drow expedition she led to the island, and has kept herself alive by becoming a kind of court jester to Vargo. Simak originally came to the cube hoping to activate its power and use it as a flying war engine, but her primary goal now is to make a safe escape. See area 6.11C for more information on Simak, and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more on the drow.

By sheer chance, a family-heirloom *amulet of the Styx* that Simak wears makes her immune to the pixelating curse, because of the Styx water it holds inside it. See the "New Magic Items" appendix for more information.

Abishai Priests. A group of **white abishai** and **black abishai** are worshipers of Tiamat whose faith saved them when Cube 1717 was nearly destroyed. Still unpixelated, they have so far avoided Vargo and are desperate to escape the island. See area 6.38 and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more information on the abishai.

Malika Tahoun. This plague-ridden **oinoloth** was the leader of the yugoloth strike force sent to the material realm to destroy the cube. As utterly selfish as all yugoloths, it surrendered to Vargo to avoid being killed. Vargo is keeping Malika around as a backup controller for the Six-Face Throne, in the event that the skull lord can't find a sufficient number of new heads. (It won't graft the oinoloth's head onto itself, because the creature's plagues can infect even its undead body.) See area 6.11A for more information on Malika, and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more on oinoloths.

Malika wears an airtight outfit that protects it from infection by the pixelating curse, and that also protects those around the oinoloth from its multitude of diseases. The mask and gloves also conceals the oinoloth's fiendish appearance.

Hydroloths. The only other survivors of the yugoloth assault lurk in what the denizens of the cube call "the Styx sea"—the volume of black Styx water that surrounds the island. While they wait for Malika Tahoun to return, they kill any creatures that might

spread the pixelating curse. See "Invisible Guardians" and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more information on the hydroloths.

RUNNING THE ADVENTURE

Six Faces of Death is a wide-open adventure, in which random chance and the players' choices are the only determiners of their progress through Cube 1717.

In the first stage of the adventure, the characters investigate the mysterious Changing Island. This stage plays out largely as a mystery and survival story, as the characters deal with deadly hydroloths, vampiric mist, the random rotation of the cube, and other threats. Figuring out how to get inside is the primary challenge of this section of the adventure—but that challenge can take many forms, depending on which faces of the cube the characters have a chance to explore.

Once they get inside, the characters' primary motivation is to fight the cube's defenders as they learn more about its origin and purpose. Against the overarching goal of rescuing the genasi mage Sladek, the characters might also decide that they're obliged to destroy the cube, wanting to prevent its destructive power from being unleashed in Faerûn.

Alternatively, instead of fighting the cube's defenders, the characters might parley with them. This could be an even more dangerous option, however, since the skull lord Vargo has diabolical plans for suitably intelligent guests. If the characters do parley with the evil defenders of the cube, take the opportunity to roleplay the disturbing, diabolical, and potentially funny personalities of those defenders.

Exploring the cube makes for a classic and challenging "invade the fortress" scenario. Pixelated creatures can all communicate telepathically with each other to a range of 120 feet, making it easy for them to advise other pixelated creatures or the skull lord of the movements and positions of intruders. If higher-level characters are having too easy a time against the cube's pixelated guardians, you can easily add additional guardians or give them maximum hit points to raise the challenge.

Pixelated merregon devils and pixelated veterans serve as the cube's guards (see the "Pixelated Guards" sidebar on the next page). Other pixelated creatures that can join a coordinated defense of the fortress include Avnas and her gray render (see area 6.17), the skull lord's personal army of zombies and skeletons in area 6.21, and the adult oblex and the balhannoth from face 5.

If the characters end up overwhelmed by the threats on the cube, you might want to throw them a lifeline in the form of unexpected help. Perhaps the shadar-kai and the drow expeditions weren't totally wiped out, and their forces are also currently exploring the cube to draw off its defenders or join in during a key fight.

On top of all the other dangers of the cube, the characters must finish their quest and escape the island before the pixelating curse transforms them into pixelated creatures. Only characters who are immune to disease can ignore this threat, and characters who can

cure disease (as well as spellcasters who can cast *dispel magic* or *remove curse*) will be kept busy.

If certain characters become infected, players who enjoy roleplaying might like the additional challenge of having infected characters become increasingly at odds with their healthy companions. Especially when a character reaches mental level 3 of the curse, let the character's player interpret their insanity rather than you telling them what their character is doing.

THE SKULL LORD'S PLAN

As all its heads once were in life, Vargo is intelligent and charismatic, and the skull lord won't foolishly rush into battle with intruders. If at all possible, it tries to approach the characters as potential allies, assuring them that despite its horrific undead appearance, it wants to be a resource for them. Vargo will describe itself as being trapped on the cube, and will encourage characters to work with it so they can all safely escape.

Vargo is never without its bodyguards (see area 6.31). But if the skull lord has the chance, it presents those bodyguards as 'captors', similar to the two pixelated guards watching Malika Tahoun in area 6.11A.

Vargo might make use of any or all of the following deceptions and half-truths when talking to the characters:

- Vargo didn't cause the pixelating curse (true), and doesn't even know where it came from (technically true). The skull lord is as ignorant as the characters are about what's going on (false).
- Vargo's enemies are ruthless evil fiends—the yugoloths—who will also kill the characters if they find them on the cube (true). Vargo and the party must work together to stop them!

PIXELATED GUARDS

Two types of guards now serve the skull lord, and can be found throughout the cube. Merregon devils (from *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*) originally served as sentries on Cube 1717, and are joined now by humanoid veterans representing both the reborn souls that once fought and died in Acheron and the adventurers and sailors that have been pixelated since coming to the island.

Transformed by the pixelating curse, a pixelated **merregon** or pixelated **veteran** has its original statistics with the following changes:

- Its alignment is lawful neutral.
- It has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can communicate only with other pixelated creatures.
- It is immune to the frightened condition.
- It has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

If you add additional guards to the adventure, you can use pixelated merregons or pixelated veterans, as you choose. Pixelated veterans might show differences in their arms, armor, and physical features, and representatives of the drow and the shadar-kai that came to the island might be found among them.

Not all the humanoids who came to the island were veterans, but using the veteran stat block is a useful shortcut during play. If any pixelated veterans are returned to their normal form, you can use other statistics for them that are more appropriate.

- Vargo is a prisoner of the pixelated creatures (false), which seek to capture the characters as well (true).
- The cube is a damaged flying battle station, which Vargo has figured out how to reactivate (true). Only sufficiently intelligent people can interface with the cube (true), and if the characters help the skull lord reactivate it, they can all make use of its power (false).
- The cube is capable of traveling from plane to plane (false). Vargo just wants to reactivate the cube so that it can leave the Material Plane (false; Vargo wants to conquer the Material Plane).
- The pixelated creatures aren't innately evil (technically true but irrelevant; the pixelated creatures' overarching goal is to spread the pixelation curse to all things).
- Vargo was a prisoner in the cube for hundreds of years, cruelly punished for trying to overthrow the cube's devil lord (true). Thus, the skull lord would never inflict such suffering on anyone else (false).

If the characters engage Vargo, the skull lord attempts to use them in one of three ways. First, it wants their aid in defeating the hydrolths that guard the waters around the cube, and in destroying the vampiric mists on the surface. Second, it hopes to see them become pixelated, coming under its control as they join its army of pixelated creatures. Third, the skull lord wants to use characters with an Intelligence of 14 or higher to attune to the Six-Face Throne, making the cube even more powerful.



PIXELATED MERREGON